

By **PABLO BOSE**

ALL IN ALL, **MORE BRICKS** IN THE WALL

INDIANS MAY FIND IT TOUGHER TO CHASE THE AMERICAN DREAM **IF TRUMP HARDENS IMMIGRATION RULES**

Donald Trump's return to the US presidency in 2025 fills much of the world with a great deal of uncertainty. Will he follow through on his promises and his threats? Will he pull the US out of international treaties and transatlantic alliances, subject neighbours near and far to tariffs and trade wars, and upend domestic politics, industries and communities through border closures and deportations? For Indian immigrants and Americans of Indian origin, life under the second Trump presidency is full of these and many other questions. It is difficult to predict exactly what might happen given Trump's notoriously mercurial nature and the already chaotic makeup of his prospective administration. Yet we might look to what happened under the first Trump administration, the promises made on the most recent campaign trail, and the policy priorities of his allies to get a better sense of what could be in store over the coming years.

There are today nearly 3 million Indian immigrants living in the US; the country is the second most popular destination for Indians (after the UAE) and Indian immigrants are the second largest foreign-born population in the US (after Mexicans). One concern Trump critics often voice is the return to the open anti-immigrant sentiments that became more common and generally acceptable in his first term. Certainly, Trump's xenophobic rhetoric did not lessen between 2016 and 2024—refugees, asylum-seekers and immigrants, especially from the Global South, remain a key target at his rallies and of his ire. However, the political calculus may have changed through these intervening years; small, but significant support grew for Trump among Black, Latino and Asian voters, enough for his base today to be seen as more multiracial than before. A few Indian Americans also occupy space in his inner circle, like Kash Patel, his nominee for FBI director, and Vivek Ramaswamy, co-leader with Elon Musk of his advisory Department of Governmental Efficiency. The presence of *desis* in Trump's orbit does not, of course, mean that the second Trump presidency will be any kinder or gentler to either the Indian diaspora living in America or for immigrants already in or planning to come to the country.

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Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**